

Content is king! This oft-repeated statement holds true on multiple counts. Content is the key factor that drives the target audience towards your business. Everything from your brand messaging to design elements to content formats—such as images, videos and animations—is what appeals to your audience and engages them. However, is a singular focus on content enough to sustain a business?

Today, users are becoming increasingly impatient with slow websites. In a report titled 'The State of Digital Lifestyles 2018,' 88 per cent people tend to get frustrated if there is a snag in content delivery. This includes such factors as rebuffering, long download times and disruptions due to errors. This figure was the highest in India and Singapore, with 92.2 per cent people registering their discomfort with such issues.

With users now accessing websites from all across the globe via different devices, businesses have to ensure they consistently deliver instant, reliable and secure access to their websites. As such, global businesses are increasingly relying on content distribution networks (CDNs) to address this prominent business challenge.

Choosing a CDN: better to begin with the end in mind

CDNs are geographically distributed data servers that assist businesses in online content distribution. These use specialised infrastructure (including global fibre cable networks) to eliminate data congestions that are frequent in the public Internet. CDNs can also detect parameters such as end-users' individual devices, firmware, applications, supported content formats and local network conditions. After analysing these, CDNs extend the most optimal content format, thereby ensuring a superior and smooth user experience. But how do businesses go about choosing the best CDN for their needs?

It begins with understanding business requirements. First and

foremost, gauge your current and future content requirements, and match them with your capital availability. Try and make this analysis as in-depth as possible by including content formats, their average sizes, volume, future rollouts, target geography, etc. This approach will help you in differentiating between the services that are or will be imperative for your platform, and the ones that you can easily avoid.

Also, set up a benchmark for both cost and quality.

Planning is integral to achieving set targets. Conduct thorough market research about your available CDN options and do a cost-benefit analysis (CBA). This will allow you to better understand how the market is changing and how your target audience is changing along with it.

Factors to consider when choosing the best CDN

Given below are the factors that must be looked at while choosing the appropriate CDN for your business needs.

Target geographies. Location of a server plays a pivotal role in media buffering. Long-distance communication introduces content latency (slow-loading content). Try to use a CDN that has a higher number of points of presence (PoPs) across your target geographies.

Also, look for higher egress capacity as it indicates the load that a CDN can tolerate during events of emergency—a phenomenon not very rare in the digital domain.

Cache efficiency. Caching prevents back and forth of data by storing critical files locally on a particular device. This, if done effectively, significantly increases browsing speed. Aim for a cache hit efficiency of at least ninety per cent. Some industry players are also able to yield cache hit efficiency of 98 per cent. Consider their services if user experience is integral to you.

Live content. Global delivery of live, location-based content experiences gets delayed due to reasons mentioned above. However, CDN-

centric technological innovations enable streaming this content in real-time across the globe in less than one second.

Cybersecurity. The digital domain inherently has a number of security threats that have to be addressed on different levels. In terms of content delivery, you should have adequate protection mechanisms including Distributed Denial of Service (DDoS) security, Web Application Firewall (WAF), TLS/SSL encryption, bot management, etc.

Technical support. CDNs, being a technology-intensive business solution, should have a constantly available technical support staff. If possible, this support staff should also have local language support. Read reviews of your prospective CDN's technical support before subscribing to it.

Be prudent. As a business leader, you should always be prudent and aptly address your future concerns before actually facing them. For instance, the world is currently battling the global warming threat. Less carbon footprint is in line with this trend, and enables a business to trade its carbon credits for monetary advantage. This directly means that a business solution that generates less carbon footprint will be more viable when stringent regulations are implied in the future.

Also, look for emerging technology solutions such as Edge computing, which will become increasingly prominent as the 5G infrastructure grows globally.

The purpose of developing a customer-centric content strategy is to keep your audience engaged across all touchpoints. However, if this content is not delivered perfectly, it needlessly makes you lose a considerable chunk of your audience. You can easily avoid this by ensuring seamless content delivery with a CDN that can accommodate all of your content needs.

These are some of the factors that will help you in zeroing in on the ideal CDN for your business. Doing so will ensure that your content continues to remain at the core of your business. **EFY**